

6. Source: Minutes of Meeting with the Swiss Ambassador, passed on by informants to local tribal leadership.

Date: October 10, 2023

Location: Swiss Embassy

Attendees: Swiss Ambassador, Health for All (HfA) Team

a. Welcome and Introduction

The team from Health for All met with the Swiss Ambassador in Beta.

b. Report Presentation by the Geneva Team

The Swiss Ambassador attentively listened to the report from the HfA Team.

He concurred with the German Ambassador's viewpoint about HfA's need to relocate its operations to Gamma, considering the complex situation in Beta and its development needs

c. Discussion on the Detained Staff's Nationality

The Ambassador inquired about the nationality of the staff detained in Beta Town, presuming they might be Swiss nationals.

The HfA Team confirmed that all members of the surgical team in Beta Town are Swiss nationals.

The Swiss government is prepared to offer additional support to secure their release, such as hostage negotiation experts from the Federal Police in Bern.

The Health for All team thanks the Ambassador for this offer but decline to have Federal Police involved in a situation that no one wants to call a hostage crisis. The Ambassador understands the situation.

d. Debate on Decreasing Activities vs. Terminating Services

The HfA Team proposed a potential flexibility from the Swiss donor, allowing HfA to scale down its activities at the hospital rather than threatening an abrupt cessation of services which prompted the current crisis.

The Swiss Ambassador expressed concerns about this strategy merely postponing the inevitable withdrawal of HfA from servicing developmental needs in Beta. He advocated for a development NGO to take over the hospital's health services, recognizing the difficulty to find such agency due to the region's instability and the lack of experience of these development organization to work in tense tribal areas.

e. Discussion on the Paradoxical Situation in Beta

Both parties acknowledged the irony that despite decreased conflict thanks to the tribal leaders mediation, no development agencies are available to function in such an unstable environment. They wait for the government to regain control over the area which would prompt further violence with the tribespeople. Essentially, no one to endorse the role of tribal leaders by providing development aid in these circumstances.

f. Safety and Security Concerns

The HfA Team voiced serious worries about the safety of staff, with fears of possible ransom demands from tribespeople and unpredictable actions from local guards if a solution is not found promptly.

They highlighted the necessity for donor flexibility to ensure smooth transitions in countries like Beta.

g. Swiss Ambassador's Recommendations and Commitment

The Ambassador cautioned against paying any ransoms to local mafias.

He endorsed collaboration with the UN coordinator, who possesses significant experience in such situations.

The Ambassador is committed to communicate with the Swiss headquarters in Bern about allocating special funds to sustain minimal health services at the hospital, such as support to deal with the emerging measles problem among children, aiming for a compromise to facilitate the release of international staff.

However, he will advise the repatriation of all Swiss nationals to Switzerland and suggests that HfA source alternative surgeons for the hospital operations.